

Ommatophoca rossii

Ross seal



Length 5½–8¼ ft (1.7–2.5 m)
Weight 290–470 lb (130–215 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location Antarctic waters

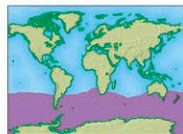


The Ross seal has a distinctively blunt muzzle, a wide head, and long rear flippers. Its fur is the shortest of any seal, and is dark gray to chestnut-brown with a buff underside and broad, dark bands along the body in both adults and pups. Less social than most seals, on ice it lives alone or as a mother–pup pair. The main food is squid, krill, and fish, caught at depths of several hundred yards. In November and December, males battle for territories around breathing holes in the ice used by females.



Mirounga leonina

Southern elephant-seal



Length 11¼–16¼ ft (3.5–5 m)
Weight ½–3 tons (0.6–3 tonnes)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location Antarctic and subantarctic waters



silvery gray fur, with scars and wounds in the male



fleshy, inflatable nose

The largest pinniped, the male southern elephant-seal is 4–5 times the weight of the female. His huge nose resembles an elephant's trunk, which he inflates when roaring at rivals during the 2-month breeding season. To establish dominance, he also rears up, slaps, and butts. The single pup is born after a gestation of 11 months (including 4 months' delayed implantation) and is suckled for 19–23 days by the ever-present mother, who loses one-third of her body weight during this time. After breeding and molting, these elephant-seals migrate south, feeding on fish and squid and diving to 2,000 ft (600 m) for 20 minutes on average.

Cystophora cristata

Hooded seal



Length 6½–8¼ ft (2–2.7 m)
Weight 440–660 lb (200–300 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Vulnerable

Location North Atlantic to Arctic Ocean



scattered dark blotches



The hooded seal has a wide, fleshy muzzle that droops over the mouth. The male intimidates his rivals at breeding time by inflating his nasal chamber to form a “hood,” which doubles his head size, and also by extruding an internal membrane from his left nostril, which also inflates like a brown-red balloon. Mainly solitary, this seal migrates when not breeding or molting, to follow the pack ice. The pup, born on an ice floe, is up to 3½ ft (1.1 m) long and 66 lb (30 kg) in weight, and is weaned in 4–5 days—the shortest time of any mammal.

Halichoerus grypus

Gray seal



Length 5¼–7½ ft (1.6–2.3 m)
Weight 220–680 lb (100–310 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location North Atlantic, Baltic Sea



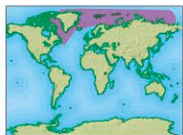
The male gray seal is gray-brown with a few pale patches; the female is paler



gray-tan. The face has large eyes, widely separated nostrils, and an angular nose. There are 3 populations: coastal northwest Atlantic, coastal northeast Atlantic, and the Baltic Sea. The first group are 20 percent heavier and breed from December to February; Baltic gray seals breed until April, and those from the northeast, from July to December. The male gray seal does not defend a set territory.

Pagophilus groenlandicus

Harp seal



Length 5¼–5½ ft (1.6–1.7 m)
Weight 265–295 lb (120–135 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location North Atlantic to Arctic Ocean



The harp seal has close-set eyes in a wide face, black fingertip claws, and silver-white fur with curved dark marks on the back that form a harp shape. It eats cod, capelin, and similar fish, migrating with the edges of pack ice. Social both on ice and in water, harp seals travel in dense, noisy groups. Pups, born February–March on ice, have yellow fur that whitens for 2 weeks before the first molt.

Pusa sibirica

Baikal seal



Length 4–4½ ft (1.2–1.4 m)
Weight 110–200 lb (50–90 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

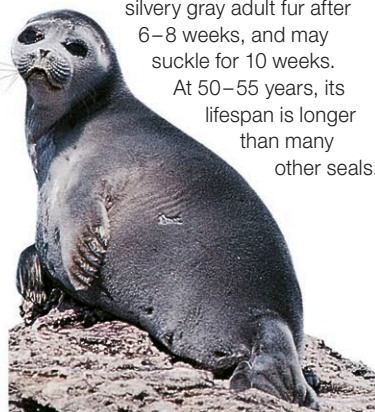
Location E. Asia (Lake Baikal)



One of the smaller seals, and the only solely freshwater pinniped species, the Baikal seal resembles its marine cousins in most respects. However, it is mainly solitary, and females tend to mate with the same male over years (serial monogamy). The single pup is born in an ice lair, molts its woolly white coat to the

silvery gray adult fur after 6–8 weeks, and may suckle for 10 weeks.

At 50–55 years, its lifespan is longer than many other seals.



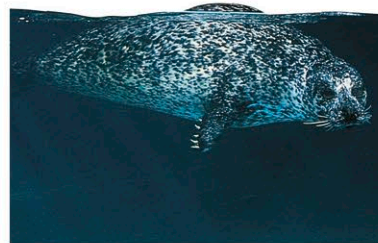
Phoca vitulina

Common seal



Length 4–6¼ ft (1.2–1.9 m)
Weight 175–300 lb (80–140 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location North Atlantic, North Pacific



Also known as the harbor seal, this is the most widespread pinniped, with 4–5 subspecies—one of them, the Ungava seal, lives in fresh water in Quebec, Canada, but is not recognized by all sources. Below the large, set-back eyes, the angled, close-set nostrils form a V shape. Color is extremely variable, mainly dark to pale gray-brown with small rings and blotches. A wide-ranging opportunist, the common seal may cause problems in fisheries. Its main prey are herring, sand eels, gobies, hake, and whiting, caught on dives of 3–5 minutes.